
INTERNET DEBATING: TECHNICAL SOLUTIONS FOR THE 21ST CENTURY

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What a long strange trip it has been. Since my efforts to use the Internet to promote debating in the mid-1990s (Snider, 1994) I have tried various techniques to integrate new information technology and new media with debating activities. Some efforts have been a success, such as creating websites for debate instruction (<http://debate.uvm.edu>) and news (<http://debate.uvm.edu/debateblog>) while others have not gone so well, such as trying to teach net etiquette to debaters (Snider, 1996).

Many debates are now videotaped and transferred to the web so that people can watch them at any time they wish. I have set up several such sites using a variety of technologies (exploration is essential) at sites like Debate Central (<http://debate.uvm.edu/watchdebate.html>) and more recently as part of a larger video log project at the Global Debate Blog (<http://debate.uvm.edu/debateblog/doctortuna/videoblog/videoblog.html>) and also archived at <http://debate.uvm.edu/debateblog/doctortuna/videoblog/Archive.html> and <http://www.uvm.edu/~debate/watch/>. Others are joining the effort.

This is not, of course, the first effort to use communication tools to expand debating opportunities. Allan Loudon (2006) has informed me that in the 1960s Franklin Shirley of Wake Forest joined a national network of coaches where debate tapes were exchanged, and remote debates in this way took place between Wake Forest, Oklahoma, New Mexico and Vermont, to name just a few. This effort lived and then died as the schools began, again,

to depend more on the actual live debate tournament for their competition.

Other efforts have shown some success but have yet to really reach their potential. One such effort has been to use the Internet to Webcast important debates (Cross Examination Debate Association Nationals, the National Debate Tournament, National Forensic League Nationals, etc.), which has been well received. This has now been done a number of times so those in remote locations can see the debate. While I was pleased to see the Cross Examination Debate Association offer a Webcast of their 2006 topic committee meeting, there is still much that can easily be done with this technology. The area where I think the potential had clearly not been realized is in arranging Internet video distance debates, where debaters in different locations can debate each other through audio and video while many others (including judges) can watch them.

Internet distance debates have been held successfully. The first such debate featured Cornell University against the University of Vermont in 1999. In 2000 the University of Vermont debated a team of British all-stars located in London. I have long been a champion of streaming Internet video debating. My original article in the NFL's magazine, *THE ROSTRUM* (Snider, 2000), describes how teams in remote parts of the world can debate each other, see their opponents as well as hear them, and judges at third locations can see and hear them in order to judge the debate. However, even though I have been able to have a number of these debates it just doesn't seem to really get off the ground.

Why? The Reasons Seem Manifold

First, everyone has to have the technology. There needs to be a digital camera, an encoding computer, a major server, a strong Internet connection, and everything has to work at once. Many people do not have these resources.

Second, the technology has to interface properly. If we were all Mac users it would be easy. Mac uses QuickTime, which allows more than one window to be open at once. Thus, viewers can see

both teams at once. However, the software for QuickTime Broadcaster is available free, but only on Macs. RealPlayer and Windows Media Player cannot have two windows open at once, so it is very difficult to get people to watch. If one party is Mac and the other Windows it is fine, but two Windows users are a challenge.

Third, it all has to be synced to a central server. Sure, we have such a server here at the University of Vermont, the university is cooperative enough, and my tech guru Wesley Wright is even willing to advise people on settings and parameters, and he has set up the requisite web page (see www.uvm.edu/debate_theater), but people have to all interface with it.

Fourth, it has to all work at the same time. Technology at both remote locations (such as Slovenia and Vermont) has to be working at the same time and then any error or problem makes the event not happen.

Fifth, the nature of the planet interferes. Time zones make it difficult to coordinate teams; with a six hour difference with Europe one group debates at 7 PM and the other at Noon. Time differences with Asia, such as China and Korea, make it even more difficult.

Sixth, viewers have to pick a time to watch the event. Unless you want to just debate for yourselves (which few want to with all the above hassle) you have to pick a time when one continent can conveniently watch and the other cannot.

Seventh, it is difficult to archive these two different streams so that people can watch the debate on demand later when they wish to. In order to watch the debate after it has happened and on-demand you have to switch back and forth between two streams. You could solve this by doing a lot of fancy editing, but if Internet debating is to be widespread and popular this just cannot happen.

Eighth, the space has to be scheduled. The pages have to be created and scheduled and people have to be guided there to watch it. Each web page has to be configured for the specific participants.

Ninth, there is a lot of technophobia in debate, and once there is a hint of complexity and challenge most people simply say “no thank you” or else say they will and then they don’t. I have scheduled several events, and even tournaments, and after strong vows to “really do it” everyone backs out.

Now we have a solution. I am certainly not surprised that I did not think of it. I thought I had a model, but now that I see the nine problems with that model I am not surprised that I failed. Enter Vedran Vucic of Serbia, who besides being a clever and creative debate coach is also extremely Internet savvy and is involved in the use of Linux servers and technology in Serbia as well as being involved in the Association for Creative Communication and Debate, a Serbian NGO.

The idea is videoblogging. I have done some introductory work on this concept (Snider, 2006).

It Works Like This

1. Serbia decides to have a debate against Vermont. We agree on a format and topic. We agree on sides. We decide who will be the judges.
2. The first team (affirmative or government) tapes their speech using a digital camera. They turn it into a video file of whatever type they want, a QuickTime file (.mov), a Windows Media Player file (.wmv) or a RealPlayer file (.rm).
3. They upload to a blog site. The blog site has the capacity to accept a video file or there can be a simple link to where the file is stored, and at the blog site they just list the topic, the team, the topic, and the format. This is the first speech.
4. Vermont watches the first speech and takes a while to come up with a response. When we have it together we tape our responding speech. We can even tape it more than once until we have one that we like. We encode it to one of these formats. We upload it. This is done within a set period of time (or not) such as two or three days.
5. Serbia watches our responding speech and prepares their own. They tape the next speech, encode it and upload it.
6. This process continues until the debate is over.

7. Assigned judges then watch the whole debate at once, clicking from speech to speech, and then send in a ballot. Or, the judges could tape a reason for decision and upload it. It could be just text or video.
8. Viewers could watch the debate whenever they wish. Or, the viewers could be the judges, and people might have a set period of time (like a week) to view and vote. So we might have to find a way to make sure they viewed the whole thing to avoid ballot stuffing, but if you are worried about that just pick three neutral judges and give them a week.
9. Announce the decision. The debate could be a one-off or part of a larger tournament. It could take place over a shorter or longer period of time.
10. The debate remains available on the videoblog for as long as desired, and people can watch it whenever they want.

I think this is a fairly elegant solution as global low-tech communication goes. It is not perfect, but I think it avoids almost all of the problems of the previous Internet debating system. Let's review them:

1. Have the technology? Many people have access to a digital camera and a computer to convert the tape to one of the formats. If you have a slow connection speed it just takes a little longer to upload. Whatever encoding tech you have works just fine.
2. Technology interface? Not needed, as people can use whatever tech they have and it doesn't need to interface.
3. Central server? Well, I can still provide that, and most universities have some server space. There are also lots of freely available storage areas that can be used, such as YouTube at <http://youtube.com/> or Yahoo Video at <http://video.search.yahoo.com/>. All we need is a link to wherever you are storing the video files. <http://debateoneworld.org> is the home of the current videoblog website I am working on.
4. Must work at the same time? Not really. You have a few days to make it work. It only needs to work at one site at a time.
5. Time zones? Not a problem. Tape it when you want, and people

can watch it when they want.

6. Viewers available? People can watch it whenever they want.

7. Archiving? It is automatic. When you upload it and provide a link everything is set.

8. Space schedule? New blog technology makes it easy and automatic to post new entries and responses. Current free software can do that easily.

9. Technophobia? Yes, well, some barriers cannot be overcome. If you don't want to debate against teams from all parts of the world because you are afraid of a laptop and a digital camera, then there isn't much we can do for you.

One barrier that is not overcome here is the lack of interpersonal contact. These technical solutions cannot supply the hand shake at the end of the debate, the immediate sense of competition in the room as speeches take place, the exchanged words and thoughts before and after the debate and other aspects of being in the same space in a physical sense. There is no way to replace these elements of a "live" debate, and for those who are close enough or able to engage in such debates, these technical solutions may not be practical or desirable. However, for those without travel resources and those separated by great distances, the type of debating described here may be an answer.

There are other solutions I am investigating, such as Skypecasting, using the free Skype videoconference technology (<https://skypecasts.skype.com/skypecasts/home>), but that will have some of the previous problems because it all happens live. I look forward to watching the work in this area by Uve Poom of Estonia and Sam Greenland of Australia.

The advantages seem huge. We can dissolve the tyranny of distance and time to bring us together at almost no cost. If you have a laptop, a computer and a video camera you are all set. This means that China can debate Poland and Chile can debate Scotland. Chile can debate Spain in Spanish. China can debate China in Chinese. Portugal can debate Brazil in Portuguese.

We Can Have a Global Debate Community

We can organize international tournaments even for those without substantial funding. You do not even have to be a team to get involved. One lone person in Croatia can decide to debate one lone person in Alaska. As long as you can agree on a language, a topic and a format, you are ready to go. Central meeting spots could be created for people to go to to find opponents with similar interests.

The possibilities are endless and I don't want to go too far in imagining the future because it might frighten some of you off. Let's just say we can try it and then see. Look for some videoblog debates in 2007 and then we can talk about it again.

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